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Eager Learners?

Digit went to Khairat village near Mumbai, the pilot site of the OLPC project in India

Asfaq Tapia

You've heard almost too much about it in the news—now here's a little first-hand report: the One Laptop Per Child (OLPC) association is a non-profit organisation that was formed by faculty members of the MIT Media Lab in Delaware in the United States to oversee the construction of an affordable laptop for children; the laptop was christened the XO. The organisation is supported by industry bigwigs like AMD, Google, eBay, Red Hat, and Intel, among

others. Each of these companies have donated approximately 7 crore to the initiative.

The OLPC project revolves around five core principles, including the fostering of the idea of ownership in children between the ages of six and 12, by providing them with their own laptops. These would have hardware and software designed for them, in keeping with their age. The project aims at promoting the constructivist way of education by donating laptops to needy schools, for free, all over the world, whenever possible, and allow them to connect and share ideas using free and open source tools.

In India, the OLPC project is supported by Reliance ADAG, which takes care of the logistics and provides the resources necessary for implementing the project in villages and small towns. That apart, the OLPC project works closely with the Digital Bridge Foundation—created by the Dhirubhai Ambani Trust—to work with interested organisations, NGOs, and volunteers in India to identify and sponsor needy schools.

The first school to be sponsored in India is Khairat School, 40 km from Navi Mumbai, close to the Mumbai-Pune expressway. We wanted to take a look at what things were like at the school now that the laptops were there, and we wanted some views and first-hand information from the people behind the project. We were half-suspecting that the laptops would just be gathering cobwebs; however, what we saw was quite different. So how exactly is this project making an impact in the lives of the children in Khairat village?

The Visit

The Khairat School comprises classes (standards) I to IV, all in one room. The XO laptops were donated to the school in October last year; the children had had some time to explore their laptops by the time we met them. The instructional material is prepared by the only class teacher of the school, Mr Surve, but Manusheel Gupta, Technical Consultant, One Laptop Per Child Inc., says they have been approached by a number of organisations interested in sharing the curriculum they've developed.



Chaitanya Surpur